



A framework for analysis

For the purpose of analysis we can divide conventions associated with visual texts into two groups – those associated with what we see in the image (the **content**) and those associated with how we see the image (the **technical construction**). These are shown in the table below.

A framework for studying visual images	
CONTENT	TECHNICAL CONSTRUCTION
Objects Animals Places • generic (e.g. beach, the outback, mountains) • specific (e.g. Paris, the Taj Mahal) People: generic • occupations and roles (e.g. doctor, mother, athlete, soldier) • nationality/ethnicity • clothing • physical appearance • body language • facial expression • gaze and bodily orientation • posture • gestures • proximity (closeness to or distance from other people) • bodily contact with other people People: specific (e.g. well-known celebrities)	Viewer perspective • viewing angle • viewing distance • framing • focus Composition • the rule of thirds • juxtaposition Leading lines Lighting and colour

Conventions of content

The use of objects, animals, places and people in visual images relies on connotation (see Chapter 3) – the ideas and feelings generally associated with these things. For example, roses are commonly associated with love, elephants with strength, the beach with relaxation and firefighters with bravery. Paris is associated with romance, James Bond with suaveness and Cathy Freeman with athletic skill. There are also connotations, in the form of **stereotypes**, associated with particular national and ethnic groups.

Stereotype

A stereotype is a widely held – usually over-simplified – generalisation about a group.

Connotation

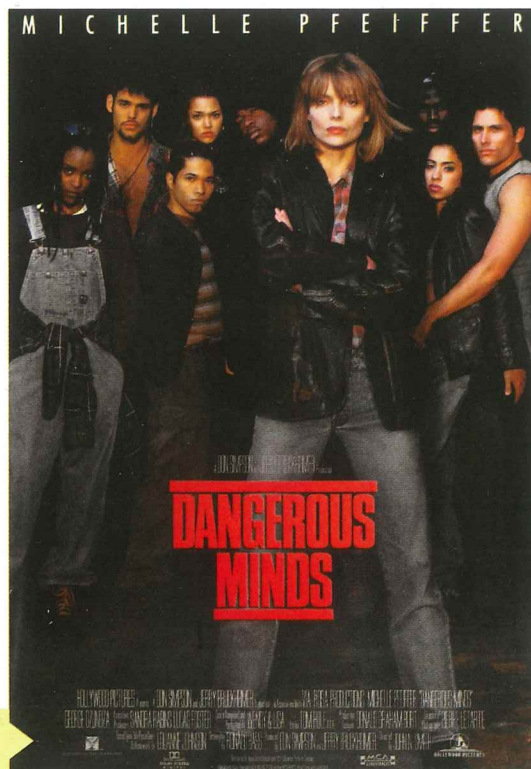
- 1 What are some of the connotations associated with the following?
 - a computers
 - b briefcases
 - c ducklings
 - d wolves
 - e deserts
 - f the Great Barrier Reef
 - g astronauts
 - h Sherlock Holmes
- 2 What objects, animals, places and/or people would you include in a visual image if you wanted to elicit the following ideas?
 - a adventure
 - b warmth
 - c sophistication
 - d danger
 - e heroism
 - f reliability
 - g freshness
 - h health

Body language

Body language plays an important role in the ideas we form about the people we see in visual images. When interpreting body language, we draw on the meanings of particular facial expressions, gestures and so on that we have learnt from our culture.

Body language

Closely analyse the body language in the poster for the film *Dangerous Minds* and discuss the ideas it conveys about each of the characters, as well as their relationships with each other.



Poster for the film *Dangerous Minds*, 1995

Alamy Stock Photo/AF archive

Conventions of technical construction

Viewer perspective

Viewer perspective refers to the way an image is constructed so that the viewer seems to be observing the subject/s of the image in certain ways. Aspects of viewer perspective include:

- viewing angle
- viewing distance
- framing
- focus.

Viewing angle

In the case of photography and live cinematography, viewing angle is referred to as camera angle, but artwork and animation can also create a viewing angle. Some examples of viewing angle are:

- high angle (where the viewer seems to be looking down on the subject)
- eye-level
- low angle (where the viewer seems to be looking up to the subject)
- aerial (where the viewer seems to be in the sky or in the air above the subject)
- oblique angle (where the orientation of an image is off the horizontal; in film, this is called a 'Dutch angle': see page 127). This perspective is often used to create a sense of mental disorientation or distress in the subject.

High angles tend to make a subject seem less important or less powerful, while low angles tend to make the subject seem more powerful, important or threatening.

Viewing distance

This refers to the distance the viewer seems to be from the subject. In photography, common terms used to describe viewing distance are close-up, medium shot and long shot. It is important to remember that these terms are relative; there are also extreme close-ups and extreme long shots. Again, the same effects can be presented in animation and artwork.

Close-ups tend to create a greater sense of intimacy between viewer and subject, while long shots tend to create a greater sense of psychic or emotional distance, often focusing our attention on the subject's relationship with their environment.

Psychic

The adjective 'psychic' means 'relating to the mind', so 'psychic distance' refers to how mentally close we feel to a character.

Framing

Framing is partly a function of viewing distance. It refers to the frame around the image of a subject, and affects what the viewer sees and does not see. Framing can sometimes have the effect of making the viewer aware of things the subject is not aware of. Framing can also be used so that it appears we are looking over the shoulder of someone and thus sharing their perspective.

Focus

Focus is a way of conferring importance. Clearly, the parts of an image that are in focus are the ones the viewer is positioned to see as most important. Those parts of the image that are out of focus are ones we are positioned to see as of some importance (otherwise they would not be included), but of less importance. Focus can also be a means of establishing mystery or suspense.

Viewer perspective

Examine each of the images below. Identify the viewer perspectives created in each and discuss:

- the relationship created between viewer and subject
- the impression conveyed of the subjects.



Getty Images/Bettman

Nosferatu, 1922



Getty Images/Warner Brothers

'Here's Johnny!': Jack Nicholson in *The Shining*, 1980



Jim Ferreira Photography

A photograph in the style of film noir.

Composition

Composition refers to how the elements of an image are arranged and is sometimes referred to as *mise en scène*. Two important aspects of composition are:

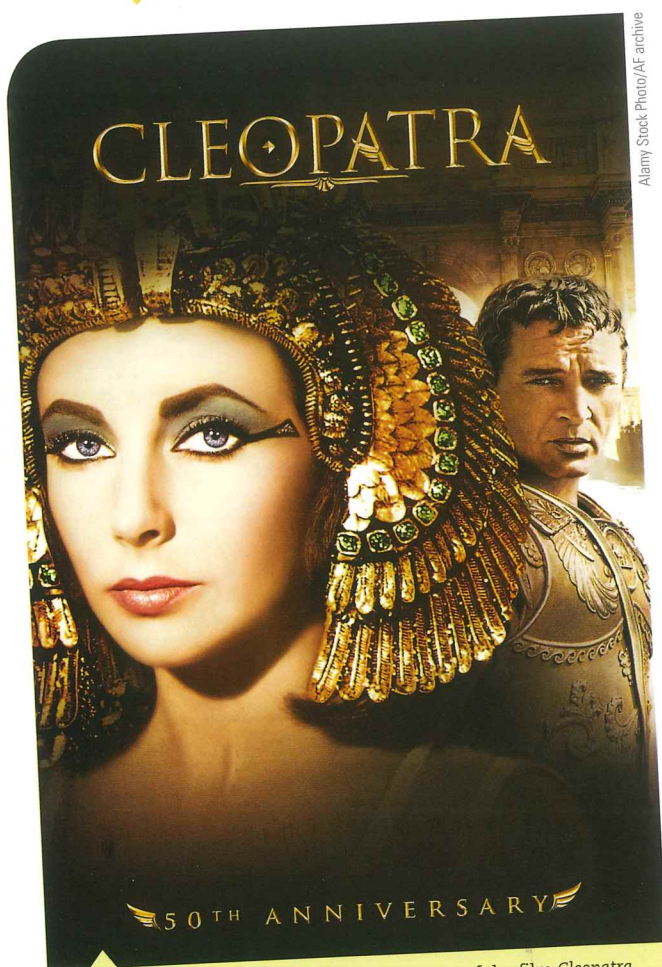
- foregrounding and backgrounding
- centring and marginalisation.

Objects that are foregrounded and centred appear more important or powerful than those that are in the background or towards the edge of the frame (marginalised).

Another aspect of composition is the size of particular visual elements in relation to others and in relation to the frame of the image. Larger objects tend to be of more central importance while smaller objects are seen to be marginal importance.

Composition

How does the composition of each of the following images, along with other visual elements, suggest the relationship between the characters?



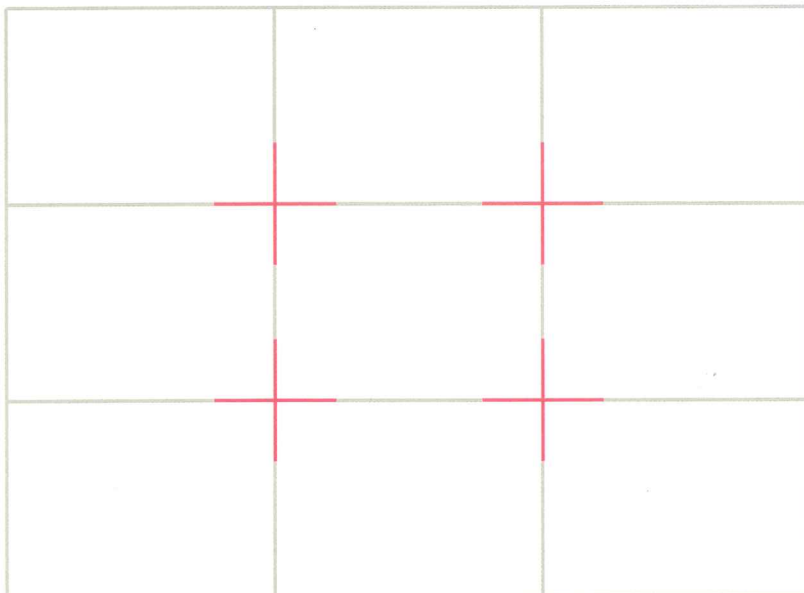
Cover for the 50th anniversary Blu-ray release of the film *Cleopatra*, 1963, starring Elizabeth Taylor as Cleopatra and Richard Burton as Mark Antony



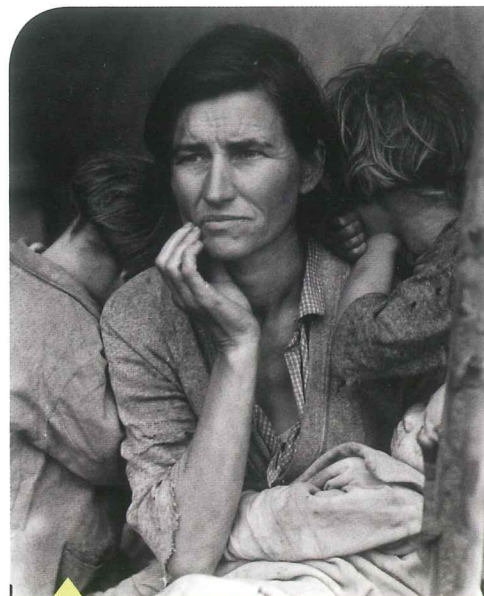
Still from the film *Witness*, 1984, starring Harrison Ford as Detective John Book and Kelly McGillis as Rachel Lapp, an Amish woman

The rule of thirds

Another aspect of the composition of a visual image is the use of the rule of thirds. Photographers and filmmakers are taught to think of an image as consisting of three equally spaced horizontal bands and three equally spaced vertical bands, so the image consists of nine parts, as in this example.



The rule of thirds



Dorothea Lange, 'Migrant Mother', 1936 (note that the term 'migrant' here refers to the fact that the woman and her family have moved from their home (in their case, Oklahoma) in search of work in another part of the USA (California))

The main points of interest in an image should be placed along one of the bands or on one of the intersection points, as the eye is naturally drawn to these. So creators of visual texts can use the rule of thirds to create emphasis and convey a sense of importance about a particular element of the image.

In 'Migrant Mother', above, taken during the Great Depression in the USA, the image is composed so that the woman's eyes are on the top horizontal band, thus drawing attention to her anxiety about the future.

Juxtaposition

Juxtaposition means the placement next to each other of two unexpected things in order to create a meaning that each thing alone would not suggest.

Juxtaposition

This image shows victims of flooding in the USA queuing up for charity relief below a billboard sponsored by the National Association of Manufacturers. Discuss the ideas about the American society of the time that are suggested by this juxtaposition.



Gerty Images/Margaret Bourke-White/Time Life Pictures

Margaret Bourke-White, 'At the Time of the Louisville Flood', 1937

Leading lines

Many images have lines that lead the eyes of the viewer in a particular direction, usually to the part of the image that is intended to be most important. Thus leading lines are a means of creating emphasis and positioning the reader to see a subject in a certain way. Leading lines can be created through natural features, physical objects, gestures, eye-lines and light, among other things. For example, in the image 'Migrant Mother' on the previous page (page 67), the woman's arm acts as a leading line that draws our attention upwards to her face.

Lighting and colour

Lighting, including the use of shadows, can play an important role in creating atmosphere and in highlighting or downplaying certain elements of an image. Because we associate certain feelings with different colours, colour can be used to evoke emotions and to associate particular ideas with the subjects in an image.

In this still from the film *Gattaca* (1997), the low lighting and muted, cold blue-grey colour palette suggest the conformity, sterility and lack of vibrance within the society of the film. However, the use of light to highlight the face of Vincent Freeman (Ethan Hawke) suggests that he is not psychologically part of this world.

Alamy Stock Photo/AF archive



Gattaca, 1997

Writing about a visual image

The thinking stage

1 Decide on how you wish – or how you are required – to analyse and interpret the text. There are at least three ways of reading an image:

- a in terms of **genre**: in other words, how the image functions; for example, as an advertisement, a magazine cover, news photograph or a social awareness poster
- b in terms of the **overt content**: in other words, the ideas conveyed about the specific people, places or events depicted
- c in terms of **representation**: in other words, in terms of more general topics, which the specific elements of the image can be seen as standing for.

For instance the Blu-ray cover of *Cleopatra* on page 66 could be interpreted in terms of:

- genre: how it works as a cover for a Blu-ray disc, enticing people to buy the product
- overt content: the ideas it conveys about the characters of Mark Antony and Cleopatra
- representation: the ways in which it represents men and women.

2 Use the visual conventions you have learnt about in this chapter as a thinking checklist, in order to find ideas related to the focus you have chosen. Remember that not all images make significant use of all the conventions we have discussed in this chapter. Do not simply engage in identifying conventions, but try to actively infer ideas from these conventions. Annotate the image if you can.

- 3 Look back at the ideas you have generated and try to discern main ideas. These are the ideas that are repeated. You might find an idea suggested by one convention, but no others. You will probably discard this idea as an unimportant part of the meaning of the image.
- 4 Try to find about three ideas for which you can offer at least two conventions each as evidence.

The writing stage

The following process can be adapted according to the nature of the topic or question you are addressing.

- 1 If necessary, indicate in your opening how the image is to be read.
- 2 Write a paragraph about each of the ideas you have identified.



Crocodile Dundee II poster: sample discussion of a visual text

One of the most prominent ideas conveyed by the image on the next page is that Australian men are powerful. This idea is conveyed in a number of ways. One way is through the composition of the image. Crocodile Dundee is shown towering, legs astride, over a cityscape, his size in comparison to the city below clearly symbolising his power in visual terms. His power is further reinforced by the knife he is wielding, its size and the light glinting off it, signifying its ability to inflict serious damage on anyone who crosses him. The character's power is emphasised even further through his physical appearance, especially the muscled arms and the strong chest that seems to be barely constrained by his vest – muscled arms and strong chests being commonly associated with physical strength.

In addition, the image portrays Australian men as confident and fearless. This can be seen in the way that, in response to the apparent danger he is facing, the man, in contrast to the woman, has his body turned front on and his gaze directly ahead, suggesting a willingness to confront any danger face on. Furthermore, in contrast to the fearful wide-eyed facial expression of the woman, the man has a slight smile on his lips, signifying a degree of amusement at the potential danger. His body language exudes confidence that he will be able to handle the threat being posed.

Furthermore, the image constructs Australian men as able to take on any environment. The man's clothing suggests that he is at home in the outdoors because he is dressed in jeans, broad-brimmed hat and bush-style vest. Especially important in conveying the outdoors as his natural habitat are the strings of teeth on his hat and around his neck, which are clearly meant to be interpreted as trophies of his victorious encounters with wild animals. The man's outdoorsy nature is reinforced by the written text, which describes him as an 'adventurer', a term that usually connotes competition against the natural environment. However, the setting of the image is an urban one, and as mentioned earlier, the composition of the image portrays the man as dominating this environment, suggesting that the skills that make him so successful in nature also enable him to cope with – indeed triumph in – any environment.

Sexual magnetism is another characteristic of Australian men according to this image. This is suggested partly by the woman's body language. While she is clutching at him for protection, the placement of her legs (wrapped around his) and her lower body (pressed into him) have a slightly suggestive sexual air. Sexual magnetism is also conveyed, as is common in many 'beefcake' images, by the glimpses of the man's bare chest. Some people might even interpret his large knife as a phallic symbol.

The previous sample is a straight analysis that does not relate the image to context, evaluate the construction of the image's representation of men or discuss the writer's own response to the text. On the next page are two more sample paragraphs that address these issues.

The image of Australian men portrayed in the poster from *Crocodile Dundee II* is clearly a flattering one. It draws strongly on many traditional ideologies about men, especially the construction of men as protectors of helpless females – an ideology reflected in stories of princes in shiny armour rescuing princesses, Tarzan movies, and countless other texts. It is a surprisingly old-fashioned ideology to find in a film as recent as 1988. Because of its flattering nature, the representation might have reflected and reinforced the ideologies of Australian males at that time, although many might have simply read the image as a ‘tongue-in-cheek’ representation of themselves as they would like to be, rather than as they really were.

I would be surprised, however, if many women, even of that time, would have endorsed the representation of themselves as helpless females contained in the image. Certainly women of the twenty-first century would reject this ideology. We no longer feel the need for a strong man to protect us, let alone one who gets his kicks by killing animals and using their body parts for ornaments. We are quite capable of looking after ourselves, thank you very much.



Alamy Stock Photo/AF archive

Comprehending

Explain how visual and written techniques in this poster discourage the use of the drug ecstasy.

Advertisement

**INSOMNIA, MEMORY LOSS OR
PSYCHOLOGICAL PROBLEMS.**

ECSTASY. FACE FACTS.



For more information call 1800 250 015
or visit australia.gov.au/drugs

NATIONAL DRUGS CAMPAIGN
NATIONAL DRUGS COMMISSION

Authorised by the Australian Government, Capital Hill, Canberra.


Australian Government

National Tobacco Campaign – More Targeted Approach, Commonwealth Government of Australia

An advertisement for an anti-drugs campaign produced by the Australian Government

Responding

- 1 Discuss the way in which the same concept or social group has been represented in different ways in two texts you have studied. Answer with reference to at least one multimodal text.
- 2 Explain how written and visual conventions work together to position readers in at least one text you have studied.
- 3 Which is more powerful in conveying ideas and attitudes: written language or visual conventions? Answer with reference to at least one text you have studied.